ancestor, Maharaja Gulab Singh. That very day in New Delhi, in a meeting attended by Mountbatten, Nehru, Patel, Baldev Singh, Batra, Menon, Abdullah, Mahajan and the army chief and IAF chief, a decision was made to provide Indian military assistance in return for the accession and for the agreement, demanded by Nehru, that the Maharaja would entrust to Sheikh Abdullah the task of forming an emergency government under Prime Minister Mahajan. The said meeting, on 26 October 1947, was attended by several people, some of whom were members of the cabinet defence committee. The Indian cabinet had established a defence committee on 30 September 1947; it consisted of both Indian and British members. The Indians were Prime Minister Jawaharlal Nehru, Deputy Prime Minister Sardar Vallabhbhai Patel, the Defence Minister Sardar Baldev Singh, the Finance Minister R. K. S. Chetty and a minister without portfolio, Sir Gopalaswami Ayyangar. The British side consisted of Lord Mountbatten and the three British Commanders-in-Chief of the armed forces. At this stage, Mountbatten took the chair. Some would say that the presence of Ayyangar is interesting; he had been the Prime Minister of Jammu and Kashmir in 1937–43 and had the reputation of being a tough taskmaster. It has been suggested that his presence in the cabinet, which he joined at the very end of September 1947, was directly related to the Kashmir problem. It may be significant that Nehru regarded Ayyangar as the only former Prime Minister of Jammu and Kashmir who had enjoyed a tolerable working relationship with Sheikh Abdullah. Ayyangar was to succeed Sardar Baldev Singh as the Defence Minister, a year later in 1948.

The very next day, on the morning of 27 October 1947, the IAF's air armada began to airlift battle-hardened Indian troops to Srinagar. The first wave, led by Lt. Col. V. R. Rai, disembarked and immediately reinforced the airfield's defences, which were under the Patiala state force's control. Within a few days, at least 35,000 Indian regular troops were involved in the defence of the valley.

Sheikh Abdullah's First Taste of Power